

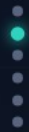
TIOBE PROGRAMMING COMMUNITY INDEX

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Ratings calculated from skilled-engineer volume, training courses, and third-party vendors across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ additional sites. The index measures how much a language is discussed — not which is "best."

• March 2026 • Paul Jansen, TIOBE Software • 50+ Languages Tracked

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain



Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

▲ RISERS

Perl 24th → 11th	+1.05% ▲ 13 positions
R 16th → 9th	+0.94% ▲ 7 positions
Swift 26th → 20th (re-enters top 20)	+0.44% ▲ 6 positions

▼ FALLERS

Go 7th → 16th	-1.49% ▼ 9 positions
C++ 2nd → 3rd	-2.90% ▼ 1 position
Java 3rd → 4th	-2.37% ▼ 1 position

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

2025 C#	2024 Python	2023 C#	2022 C++	2021 Python
2020 Python	2019 C	2018 Python	2017 N/A	2016 Go



The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

PYTHON: DOMINANT BUT DECLINING

At **21.25%**, Python leads by 2× over #2. But its **-2.59pp** year-over-year drop is the largest among the top 5. Monitor whether this signals a plateau or the start of a longer decline.

LEGACY LANGUAGE REVIVAL

Perl 24 → 11, **R** 16 → 9, **Fortran** stays top 15. Entrenched communities in scientific computing, data analysis, and infrastructure continue to sustain these languages.

C SURGES BACK

+2.02pp gain, climbing from 4th to 2nd. C has held top-2 across four decades — its resurgence underscores enduring demand in embedded, systems, and OS-level work.

GO'S SHARP FALL

7th → 18th (**-149pp**) — the largest absolute drop of any top-20 language. Possible displacement by **Rust** (14th, +0.09%) in the systems programming space.